

Cities

The first cities were built about 7,000 years ago, amid fertile farmlands. Over time, many cities became rich through trade. Their wealth attracted raiding armies, so high walls were built around the cities to protect them from attack. Some of these ancient settlements are still thriving cities today. Modern cities, however, look very different, with geometric street plans and high-rise buildings of steel and glass.



THE FIRST CITIES

About 7,000 years ago, farming in Mesopotamia (present-day Iraq) produced enough wealth to support the first cities. These are now ruined, but similar cities of narrow alleys and mud-brick houses survive in countries such as Morocco, North Africa (left).



CITY-STATES

Cities often become centers of culture and civilization. This was the case in the city-states of Ancient Greece, which were ruled like small countries. Athens (above) was the greatest of these, but modern examples such as Monaco and Singapore also flourish.

TRADING WEALTH

Cities need food and other goods, which are supplied by traders. All the buying and selling in their busy marketplaces generates profits and wealth, which encourages more trade and more wealth. Many cities lying on major trade routes grew rich in this way, and their wealth paid for spectacular buildings designed to impress.

The city of Samarkand is more than 2,700 years old.

